Three, I hadn't achieved anything yet. But maybe this was my time to show that, one day, I might. It wasn't just me, of course. Nor was it just my generation. It's still true now: just ask Wes Brown or John O'Shea or Kieran Richardson. The manager has always had faith in the players who have been produced at the club. One of the best things about coming through the ranks at Old Trafford is that the boss involves the younger players in training—and gives them a game, too—as soon as he feels they're up to it. He believes in the lads who have grown up at the club and, above everything else, that's something for which my generation will always feel grateful to Alex Ferguson. The future isn't a responsibility he hands over to someone else. When I was a boy, he knew who David Beckham was. Once I'd signed for United, he was following my progress the whole time: coming to games, watching training, talking to Eric and the other coaches about how I was getting on.

When it comes to making a League debut, or even getting a start in a Cup game for United, you already feel like you're part of the first-team set-up. That makes it easier for any young player to relax and do his best when he's given his chance. With me, it seemed like I'd been involved at least since I was a kid, warming up alongside my heroes at Upton Parkas club mascot for the afternoon. By the time I was ready for United's first team, I already got on well with the senior players. It wasn't a case of: who's this young so and so, coming in and thinking he can take our place? I knew them all and, just as important, they knew me.

As it turned out, my first Premier League game was a bit of an anticlimax. There's always a big atmosphere for Man United vs Leeds, whether we're playing at Old Trafford or at Elland Road, and the ground was buzzing beforehand. It was an incredibly hot afternoon, though, and the match was stifled because of that. It finished 0–0. I must have done all right because I played a few more League games before the end of that season and, by the summer, it felt as if, slowly but surely, things were starting to happen. What I didn't realize, and none of us did, was that the manager had already seen enough and was ready to take one of the biggest gambles of all time. The season 1995/96 was the making of me. It was the making of all of us, thanks to a boss who believed in us even before we believed in ourselves.